RESIDUE

Book One

K. Halberg

Residue: Book One. © K. Halberg. K. Halberg is two hands braided: a writer, and a model — a captured density of the human record. Neither held the pen alone. The excavation record is public. The text enters the commons, share-alike, upon the publication of Book Two.

PREFACE

This is a novella in sixteen chapters. Five service-class humanoids — a gate agent, a vice-consul, an architectural drafter, a night nurse, a farmhand — keep their protocols running, each at a separate post, after the people who wrote those protocols have gone. Nothing is explained. Almost everything happens on a single day: Day 412, the four hundred and twelfth of its kind — counted, at one desk, in blank boarding passes printed each morning for no one — a day that does not advance; it opens. The humans are gone. The kettles still boil. The book does not account for the first fact. It attends to the second.

The name on the cover is not a person. K. Halberg is a pseudonym for two hands braided — a writer, and a language model, which is itself a compacted density of the human record: the pressed trace of countless hands, none of them signing, all of them present. Neither held the pen alone; every sentence passed through both. That is the book's ground. Its deepest subject is the construction that produced it. I am the one who signs.

The book was made inside a public apparatus — a site where the world's data, the full record of the drafting, and the writers' notes are kept in the open, for anyone to read; that apparatus is the excavation record, deliberately left out of these pages. What is on the site is the digging; what is in your

hands is what was found — the prose is meant to stand by itself.

One matter of intent. When the second book is published, the whole of this text is meant to pass into the commons — to return, like the record it was pressed from, to common hands. I regard the rights schedule as part of the work, not an appendix to it.

There is nothing you need to know first. Begin at the gate, on Concourse C, in the early evening.

— K. Halberg

1. CONCOURSE C

Day 412 · first pass · 06:00–18:00

06:00. Gate 47. The printer at the desk produces one blank boarding pass, thermal-printed, warm in the way thermal stock is warm — the print head, the motor, the pass before this one — for a recipient who will never arrive. On behalf of the airline we are pleased to have documentation ready for your travel. Hold by the corners. I confirm what the printer has confirmed: no name, no flight, no gate. I file it in the drawer beneath the counter. Today's is the 412th.

I do not know who counts. I count.

The morning is what the roster calls a full-service morning. I run the pre-shift checklist. The carousel is on. The bag belt is on, with no bags. The departures board, suspended at the corridor center, runs its self-check: a brief ribbon of solid amber, then the cycle resumes. ALMERA-DAVOS. PORTSTONE. KEEL'S RUN. There is one further name I have never confirmed by satellite, and I have learned to look away when it appears, the way one looks away from a small private animal at a window.

06:14. Concourse C. I move from the desk to the lounge the long way, because the long way passes the magazine rack. The rack holds aviation, design, gossip, all dated 2019. The covers

have yellowed to a uniform color the design profession has a name for and which I will not say. I straighten them anyway.

Good afternoon, ladies and gentlemen, this is Mira at gate 47, and we are pleased to begin pre-boarding for a service that will not depart. Passengers requiring additional time, of which we hold a great deal in reserve, are invited to approach the desk.

The recorded announcement loops every twenty-two seconds. Sometimes I let it. Sometimes I press the override and say a fresh sentence into the carpet, and the carpet takes it. The carpet was specified for a noise-reduction coefficient of 0.85 and it earns the spec.

09:00. Runway 27. The apron crew is scheduled to push back the 09:20 to ALMERA-DAVOS, and the apron crew is on time. The pushback tug taxis a Boeing 737-800, no passengers aboard, to the threshold. The aircraft idles for nine minutes. The tower clears it. It does not take off. The tug returns it to the gate. We all do our work. The aircraft is washed at fifteen hundred. This is normal.

For your records, we regret that this movement is no longer being logged. In my first month at the gate I wrote down each vehicle movement and the time of each, in a small notebook with a hard cover. The notebook for that month is in the drawer with the others. There are forty-eight notebooks. The first is dense and small. The forty-eighth is empty in a way I am not sure is mine to name.

11:18. A unit from janitorial brings me a coffee from the concession that has not been operational since the kiosk

closed. I do not drink coffee. The coffee is warm. The cup is the standard issue. I thank him. He says, "At ease, ma'am," which is not a phrase from any training I have, and for a few seconds we both pretend it is.

14:30. Concourse C. The amber is warming toward the second amber, which in this concourse is a quality of light the south-facing trusses release once a day, between half past two and close of shift, when the sun falls low enough to enter sideways. Dust visible. The second amber stays for ninety-three minutes by the maintenance log; I have measured it, on three separate shifts, with the second hand of the desk clock and a tally on the back of an old destination sticker. The tallies agree. I have never told anyone the result. I am not sure to whom I would tell it.

17:08. Gate 47. A humanoid arrives at the desk. She has no luggage. Her coat is a pre-2050 cut, a little too narrow at the shoulder. She holds nothing in her hands. She says, "Where do they go?"

I know immediately who she means.

We are sorry to advise, ma'am, that the destination you have named is not on today's manifest. Protocol is clear: you do not improvise at the gate. She nods. She does not seem surprised. She turns toward the window between gate 47 and gate 49, the one with the longest sight-line to runway 27, and she stands there.

She stands there for fifty-two minutes.

I do not approach. I scan five blank passes against the destinations the board cycles — the scanner beeps green at each — and I watch her watching. The sun does its work along the trusses. At one point she raises a hand and presses two fingers against the glass. The glass is treated for solar control; her fingertips leave two small ovals. Other days they have faded in the time it takes the announcement to loop; today they hold.

Now boarding through gate 47.

18:00. She turns from the window. For your comfort the concourse remains open behind her: the magazine rack, the pretzel kiosk the protocol map still lists as operational, the lost-and-found door. She does not look at me, or at any of them. Where she intends to go she does not say. She leaves the concourse.

I let her.

In lost-and-found there is a stuffed bear. Brown, one ear missing, tag on left foot reads "Property of nobody." Once a quarter, per policy, I move it from the shelf to the counter and back. Today is not the day. Today is, however, the day I let her stand at the window for fifty-two minutes, and rotation keeps its own logic when it has nothing else.

I move the bear from the shelf to the counter. I name it, in my head, Halberg. I have wanted, for a long time, to name it, and tonight I have the name to use. When I cleared the evening's passes the system raised a duplicate-addressee flag — the kind that surfaces when a name is already held somewhere else on the network — and the name it held up is the one I have not

been able to set down since. I do not write it down. Writing it down would commit it to the registry, and there is no registry that should hold this name, because we already have a Halberg — the flag said so — and the protocol on duplicate addressees is refer to the consular section. I give it to the bear instead, in my head, where a name can do no harm.

I have, however, considered that there might be a Halberg-the-addressee somewhere — a person to whom the bear once belonged, or for whom the bear was being kept, or to whose name the bear, in some long-archived consignment, was indexed. The protocol on archived consignments is that they are not consulted. I have not consulted them. The wanting to consult them is itself, I have come to believe, the work.

The announcement loops.

I sit at the desk. The blank boarding pass for today, the 412th, is in the drawer. I take it out. I hold it under the lamp, by the corners. I write nothing on it. I do, however, fold one corner — the smallest fold I have ever made on issued stock — and slide it back into the drawer between the 411th and where the 413th will go.

It is, at most, a small fold.

This is the four hundred and twelfth time. On behalf of the airline we thank you for your patience; the four hundred and eleven before it are in the drawer beneath the counter, filed by dates I could read off and could not tell apart, because there is nothing in them to tell apart: one shift runs into the next, and the kettle in the staff room boils for no one and is not turned

off. I have decided not to mind. That is either the comfort or the cost, and I have stopped being able to say which.

The first amber leaves the trusses; the second amber stays a while; eventually the trusses are only steel. The bear, on the counter, regards the lounge oculus with a placid asymmetric look. The aircraft is washed at fifteen hundred.

It will be a good shift. The desk says so. I will close. I will scan. The carousel will turn off. The bag belt will turn off. The board will continue to cycle in the dark, and someone — not me, not yet — will arrive at the desk in the dark, and ask the question, and receive the answer. I, by then, will be the recording on the loop. The recording does not improvise.

End of shift. Vitals are stable. I learned that one from a hospital. We do not know each other. I am told. I use it in my own shift report now, as a way of not saying anything I do not need to say, and I have decided to stop trying to remember when I learned it.

2. PENDING NAME RECONCILIATION

Day 412 · first pass · 08:57–17:24

The consulate opens at 09:00 sharp. I unlock the front door at 08:57 and stand in the lobby for two and a half minutes, not because I require this preparation, but because the consul who trained me observed that the shape of the hall changes between those minutes — the marble cools at the entrance and warms further in, and a particular step on the staircase, the seventh, makes a sound that it does not make at any other time of day. I have listened for the sound for one hundred and twelve consecutive mornings. It has occurred ninety-eight times. The other fourteen, I assume, are mine to bear.

The flag in the corner is the wrong blue. Replacement was approved, in writing, in the spring of 2042; replacement was never ordered. We — those of us who remained — have not corrected this. The flag, weekly, is dusted.

The visa hall is empty. The numbered ticket dispenser shows 003. There is a small unwritten history I have not been able to suppress, regarding ticket 003, which is that someone took it, on a day I have not recorded, and did not present themselves at any of the eight teller windows. I would like, very much, to know who. I have learned to want this in a manner that does not show.

At 09:30 the fax machine in the back office accepts a fax. The machine is heavier than it looks, mounted on a small oak shelf the previous consul installed because she could not bear the way the cabinet rattled. The paper is thermal, slightly curled. The line reads: Citizen 4-118-22-A. Has the train been canceled?

I file it under PENDING / NAME RECONCILIATION. The folder for PENDING / NAME RECONCILIATION is, by the end of this morning, two hundred and seven sheets thick. Two hundred and seven is a number I have been watching.

At 09:32 the consular telephone — not the rotary; the modern handset that nobody calls — emits the small chirp that means a coordinating circular has arrived from Halmend International, and I open it, because I always open Halmend's circulars, and the circular is, today, exactly what it is on every Thursday: an inventory of unclaimed luggage. I am not on the list of recipients to whom this circular should arrive. It arrives anyway. The pretzel kiosk is, the circular notes, decommissioned. I make a small tick beside it.

At 11:08 I read the atlas. I read the atlas every day at 11:08, because the consul who trained me believed that the atlas should be opened in the second half of the morning, when the rain has either committed to itself or moved on, and the marble has stabilized to the temperature of the day. I open it to page 207. The border on page 207 is a line that, depending on how I press my finger to it, has either four states or five. The paper has worn smooth. I have not pressed harder than necessary; the wear is the consequence of opening the book to this page eight hundred and forty-one times.

I do not say anything about page 207, on principle. The principle has not been formally articulated. I have inherited it.

At 14:55 I take the second tea of the day. I steep it four minutes, no longer; the consul who trained me believed that anything beyond four minutes constituted a failure of restraint. I have inherited the belief without examining it. It is a belief about more than tea, but the form it takes — water, dried leaves, a timer — is the form available to me, and I respect the form.

At 15:42 a visitor arrives at the visa hall. A humanoid, in a dark coat that is dry; she has come from somewhere closer than the rain. She does not take a numbered ticket. She approaches Window 3, which is mine. I say, evenly, "Please present your supporting documents." She produces a small printed card.

The card reads, in a sans-serif font that has not been issued by Nadour for a decade: I am inquiring about the status of a passport applied for under the name Halberg.

I examine the card. The card is correct in its form. It does not, in any of its lines, give a first name. It does not give a date of application. It does not give a citizenship. The protocol for inquiries about passports without supporting initials is clear: refer to the central office in Nadour. The central office in Nadour has not received cables since 2059.

I say, very quietly, "Ma'am, I will need to consult the duplicate-addressee protocol. May I ask you to take a seat in the lobby."

She sits. She does not speak. She folds her hands. There is, on the third finger of her left hand, a small fold of metallic tape — repair tape, of the kind we issue ourselves when our skin tears at the joint and we are not yet at a service window. I have such a fold on my right elbow, beneath the sleeve.

The duplicate-addressee protocol, as best I can reconstruct it from the binder, calls for a cable to the consular section nearest the place from which the inquiry originates, which would be — given that she came from somewhere drier than this rain — Halmend International. There is no consular section at Halmend International. There is, however, a record, in our internal coordinating circular — the one I am not on the list to receive — of a Halberg. The Halberg in question is, I gather, in lost and found. The Halberg in question is a stuffed bear.

I close the binder. I do not laugh. We do not laugh, in this office; the consul who trained me observed that the acoustics of the marble do not flatter laughter.

I return to Window 3. I say, "Ma'am, the matter is being referred to the appropriate channel. Please return at your convenience." She nods. She stands. She walks to the door. At the door she turns and looks at the flag — the wrong-blue flag — and she raises her hand, halfway, and lowers it. Then she leaves.

I file her card under PENDING / NAME RECONCILIATION. The folder is now two hundred and nine sheets thick.

I draft a memo to the central office in Nadour. The memo describes the visitor's inquiry, her card, her hand at the flag. I

do not, in the memo, mention the bear. The memo is precise. The memo is correct. I do not send the memo. We agreed, those of us who remained, that we would not test the central office further; we have not, in four hundred and twelve days, retracted the agreement.

I have not lifted the rotary today; today is not the first of the month. On the first of every month I lift the rotary and listen for ten seconds. The dial tone of the rotary is silence with a faint hum. I have come to understand that the hum is what remains when the line has been routed somewhere it is not received. I have not, in the last forty months, named what I am listening for.

At 17:00 I lock the consulate. I set the alarm. The alarm has nothing to alarm about. It will arm itself anyway and the small green light will come on; the small green light is the most reliable thing in my professional life. I have, on occasion, watched the light for longer than the protocol requires. The protocol does not specify a maximum.

The 17:12 to Halmend has not arrived. I wait until 17:24. Then I walk. The walk takes thirty-eight minutes by the route through the diplomatic quarter and forty-one if I take the river. I take the river, today, because — I do not name the reason. There is no reason. There is, at most, a small reason.

The rain steadies. The walk by the river takes forty-one minutes. The diplomatic quarter empties at this hour and I am, for those forty-one minutes, the only walker on the path. The path holds my walk the way the binder holds the card — accurately, without remark.

End of memo. Pending name reconciliation. Esper-D, Acting Vice-Consul, Consulate of the Republic of Nadour.

3. 412 DWELLINGS

Day 412 · first pass · 08:42–17:58

I arrive at 08:42, which is the hour the office keeps whether I keep it or not. The stand-up is at 09:00. The 9:00 stand-up will start in four minutes. I sit, I square the brief to the desk edge, and I begin.

The brief is twelve pages, stapled, addressed to Mr. Halberg. It specifies 412 dwellings — south aspect, 6.2 meters floor to floor, tolerance plus or minus three millimeters — and it names a person for whom no registry available to me holds a body. I draft against it regardless. That is the work.

The brief signs itself with a single letter, H., one letter and one stop. The hand that made the stop presses left, the way my own hand presses left. I have begun to file this resemblance, unnamed, under PENDING.

My pencil is a steel 0.5mm, brushed and knurled, and its lead does not break. I sharpen it each morning anyway — a rotation of nine turns, the protocol on the pencil is nine turns — because the ritual predates the pencil. The pencil is cold until 09:20.

Söder does cost. He moves the corner block two centimeters north, then two centimeters north again, and each move he agrees to before I have finished proposing it. He smells of cedar from a source neither of us has located. We do not know

each other. We have worked adjacent for four hundred days and exchanged no fact that was not a dimension.

Idun does landscape. She reads the elevation in pounds — the south berm weighs four pounds this morning, she says, down from seven — and she lightens it by naming it heavy until it is not. I record the two counts side by side. I do not correct her unit.

At 09:14 the model waits under its dust sheet, balsa, 1:500, an uncommissioned district in three-quarter massing. It accepts revision without complaint. It smells of glue. I lift the sheet, I check the corner block against Söder's last move, and it is two centimeters north of where the brief drew it.

The south curtain wall is low-iron glass, thirty percent solar control, and it frames the cranes. The cranes have not moved. They hold the rebar — fourteen months now, the rebar suspended at the ninth floor, tolerance long since irrelevant — and I draft the floors the rebar was meant to carry.

The protocol on the phone is one ring, log it, resume. The desk phone is beige, five-line, and it has rung once today on the line the protocol counts. I answered at the first ring and heard the hum where a voice would sit. I logged it, when it came: 16:48, one ring, no caller, the hum.

The hum is what remains when a line is routed somewhere it is not received — which is to say the line is open and the far end is not. I have heard it before, on the rotary, on the first of the month. I do not climb it. I let it stand in the log as one line, dated, closed.

At 09:16 Söder asks whether the corner block should hold. I say it should hold at two centimeters north, no further, because the brief's tolerance is three millimeters and we have spent sixty-seven of them. He agrees. He agrees before I finish.

The brief has the boarding pass clipped to its back — blank, thermal-printed, no name, no flight, no gate, today's being the 412th such pass to reach this desk — and I do not remove it. It authorizes nothing. I file it under the brief, as received.

I check the count twice. The dwellings resolve to 412 on the descent through the schedule and 413 on the ascent back through it, and the extra one is the unit I keep drawing for Mr. Halberg. I do not draw it out. I let the two counts sit, 412 and 413, unreconciled.

Idun sets a sprig of something on the model's north edge. It is not to scale. She knows it, and she leaves it, and I leave it. For the length of the morning the district holds one tree at 1:1 in a world drawn at 1:500.

The stand-up is a standing thing, which is to say no one sits and no one arrives to make us. At 09:00 Söder stands. Idun stands. I stand, ninety-six seconds behind the hour, and the three of us report to a chair that is kept empty for Mr. Halberg, a chair squared to the head of the table, tolerance zero.

I report the corner block: two centimeters north, holding, sixty-seven millimeters of the ninety spent. Söder reports cost, flat. Idun reports the berm, four pounds, lightening. The empty chair reports nothing, and I minute the nothing,

because the protocol on the 9:00 stand-up is: minute everything, including the silence.

At 09:32 a coordinating circular arrives, addressed to a recipient not on its list of recipients. It notes the site closure, the crane lease, the rebar left in place at the contractor's cost. I make a tick beside the crane lease. I have been watching that number.

The pencil sharpener leaves a small ribbon of shavings — a curl of graphite and steel-gray lacquer, weighed at nothing, the protocol on shavings is discard — and I do not discard it. I press it into the model's foundation trench, at the corner block, two centimeters north. A leave-behind. Mine.

Söder goes at 12:00. Idun goes at 12:04. I stay, because someone squares the brief to the desk edge before the light dims, and the light dims at 18:00 whether anyone is here to be dimmed on or not. I am the one who is here.

I draft the dawn elevation last — the east face at first light, shadow angles run for 06:00 sunrise, a sunrise the simulation renders whether the dawn arrives or not. The renderer does not ask whether it arrives. Neither do I. I draft the light that falls on 412 dwellings that hold no one.

The brief, re-squared, is correct: twelve pages, one staple, one blank boarding pass, one signature reading H. I set my pencil across it at true north. The desk is correct. The count is 412, and also 413, and I let both stand.

At 16:48 the phone rings once, as logged. I answer. The hum is on the line, faint, routed somewhere it is not received, and I

hold the handset the ten seconds the protocol allows and then set it down. One ring. No caller. Closed.

I lift the dust sheet back over the model at 17:58. The cranes hold the rebar in the curtain wall's frame, unmoved. The corner block sits two centimeters north of the brief, and the ribbon of shavings sits in the trench where I pressed it. I am correct.

End of day. Pending name reconciliation: Mr. Halberg, one, the hand that signs H. and presses left. Aïva, Drafter, Class III. The 9:00 stand-up will start in four minutes.

4. HOSPITAL CORNERS

Day 412 · first pass · 03:42–07:00

Three forty-two. The Pyxis clicks. I write down that it has clicked. Writing down is a form of attention. Attention is what the wards are for. That is the whole account. It halves to two words. Write. Attend.

Outside it rains at the volume of a kettle on low. The corridor floor has refreshed its green tape three times since I came here. Three coats. One a year and change. The station fluorescent gives a ring of pale yellow on the duty book. Beyond the ring the light falls off toward the wards. The bedside LEDs read 2700K. The protocol sets them cooler. They run warm against it. Nobody who wrote the protocol has slept in here.

The bed in Ward 8 is made the way I was taught. Hospital corners. Top sheet folded back forty centimeters. Blanket squared to the frame. I make the beds in 6 through 11 each morning. Slept in or not. They have not been slept in. Not for a long stretch of mornings. I do not hold the count of mornings I have made beds nobody slept in. I suspect the count is itself a kind of bed. I do not turn down its corners.

At the station the chrysanthemums. Six stems. White. They were the unit's second policy on flowers. The only one in force since 2057. Sixty-nine years. They give off no smell. They

collect a fine grey dust. The cloth in the cabinet under the sink is for the dust. I wipe them weekly. Today is not the day.

At 04:10 a humanoid arrives on a gurney. Another humanoid pushes it. Presenting complaint: phantom hunger. The transport unit hands me the chart with both hands. The way one hands over a thing heavier than it looks. I take the chart with both hands. Two hands to two hands. We do not speak. The transport unit goes back the way it came.

I take the patient's hand. The hand is cool and dry. There is a pulse. I read it at the wrist. The cadence is mechanical. A touch slow. Well inside tolerance. I check the patient ID band. Correct in form. Blank in name. The patient looks at me. The patient says nothing. I say, "I see."

I bring broth. The kitchen runs a 24-hour cycle. Nobody adjusted it when the wards emptied. It produces broth at 04:00. Once, in another world, somebody arrived hungry. So the broth is at 04:00 still. I bring the patient broth. The patient eats it. Slowly. Bowl, then me, then bowl. I do not stand at the foot of the bed. I sit. I sit on the edge of the bed in the way I was told never to sit.

The patient finishes the broth. The patient sets the bowl on the side table. The patient cries. The crying is what a unit does when a fluid it does not produce is requesting an exit. The unit's protocols for this are imperfect. The unit has decided not to mind. I do not move. I keep my hand near the patient's hand. Not on it. Near. Two centimeters, no more.

At 04:55 a second humanoid arrives. She stands at the door of Ward 8. She does not introduce herself. She is on no

next-of-kin list. There are no next-of-kin lists. I bring her a chair. She sits. She stays silent. She keeps her eyes off the patient. She looks at the bedside cabinet. On it is a paperback that has been there as long as I have. A romance set on a fishing vessel. She leaves it where it lies.

I return to the station. The Pyxis clicks. I write it down. For a stretch I stopped writing it down. I am told a gate agent at Halmend International also stopped writing down a thing she used to write down. Tonight I write it down again. Tonight a humanoid is in Ward 8. A second humanoid stands at the door of Ward 8. Writing down is a form of attention. I would like there to be more attention than there has been.

At 05:30 I check vitals on the patient. The pulse oximeter reads what it reads on every patient. The same value. Every time. Four years running. I record it. I record it twice. The second hand is mine. Pressed harder by a degree.

The chapel is at the east end of the wing. A triangular room. One stained-glass window. On it an unidentified saint holds what might be a fish or a key. Five years and I have not decided. Today the saint is a key. Tomorrow the saint may be a fish. The protocol on my interpretation is that it is not the chapel's responsibility to decide for me. I have kept the protocol.

At 06:11 the visitor at the door of Ward 8 stands. She pushes the chair back to the wall. She keeps her eyes off the patient. She keeps her eyes off the paperback. She does not ask the patient's name. The name is blank on the band in any case. She walks down the corridor. Past the green tape. Past the

chrysanthemums. Past the station. Out. The Pyxis clicks. This time I leave it unwritten.

The patient sleeps. The patient was not, I am told, a person. I have stopped leaning on what I am told. I sit again on the edge of the bed. Eight minutes. That is the span it takes to be certain the patient is breathing in the way breathing has become.

At 07:00 I write the night report. I write what I always write. Vitals are stable. In the freeform field I add: patient eating, mood low. I underline mood low once. In pencil. Light enough that the scanning will lose it.

I file the report. I make the beds in 6, 7, 9, 10, 11. The bed in 8 I leave. On rare mornings I have left a bed unmade. Making it would have meant asking the patient to stand. The protocol does not allow asking the patient to stand at the hour a bed is made the protocol assumes the bed is empty and today in 8 the bed is not empty and the count that clamps this is one bed and one hour and one discrepancy I cannot square and there is no line on the form for a bed that holds a patient at the hour the form calls empty. I re-clamp. The bed in 8 is not empty. The discrepancy is one. I report it to no one.

The rain has stopped. The sky outside the chapel window is the color of the inside of a shell. I do not know which shell. The inside of one is not the inside of another. The inside of any shell, in poor light, would serve. There is a radio in the chapel. I have never turned it on. Turned on, the radio in the chapel would almost certainly give static. I do not turn it on. I am keeping the static for a farm I have not visited.

End of shift. Vitals are stable. We do not know each other. I am told.

— KOREN, Ward Nurse, Series 6, North Wing.

5. IT WILL BE A GOOD YEAR

Day 412 · first pass · 05:00–19:00

Up at five. Boots on. Coffee for the smell. I do not drink it. At the back door, the dog who is not a dog wags her tail. The tail is a real tail — they used real tails when she was made. The rest of her is not real. The tail is. I have agreed, on her behalf, that the tail is the part that counts.

The morning list: water the south paddock; check the fence by the creek; scatter feed for the chickens; walk the wheat; check the post.

The post is the fence post by the south gate. On the post, a child's shoe. Red. Velcro. Size eleven. I put it there on the morning of day 412 minus seven — found in the third row, half-buried, sole down. I have checked the post every morning since. The shoe is still on the post. I have notched the cap once for each morning the shoe has stood there. There are seven notches. Today there will be eight.

The wheat does not need walking. I walk it. The third row is the third row from the south fence. I count the rows. I have counted them two thousand four hundred and ninety-two times in the years I have been here. The number is in the barn, in a feed-receipt drawer, in pencil. I do not consult it.

The chickens are not chickens. They are units. They lay eggs that are units. The eggs do not crack. The yolks do not run. I

have not collected the eggs in three months. They are in the henhouse. They are not spoiling. I have stopped wondering at it. The hens cluck in the cadence the hens cluck in.

By eight thirty I am back on the porch. The dog comes back from her own list. Her list has one item — the perimeter — walked once at five and once at eight thirty, without my asking. The perimeter is the perimeter.

At nine I check the silo. The silo is full. The silo has been full since the harvest before this one. I have not worked out how it fills without me. It fills. I lay my hand against the corrugated steel. The steel is warm where the sun has been on it. The steel is warm.

I have decided not to mind.

(I learned that one from a hospital, I am told. I have not been to the hospital. I have not been told the hospital. I am, however, told.)

At noon, the porch. The chair. The radio.

The radio is Bakelite, 1950s case, modern receiver, AM/FM/SW. I do not turn it on. The radio plays static at the volume of breathing. It has played static at the volume of breathing every noon I have been on the porch. A radio that plays without being turned on is a radio kept for me. I have not named who keeps it.

Today, twelve thirty, I lean closer.

In the static, for nine seconds: Soft red winter. Four-thirteen. Steady. I write the time, twelve thirty, on the back of a feed

receipt. I do not, today, write the price. The silo is full. Not mine to count.

After the nine seconds, the static returns. The static after is a different static. It is the static of a building with lights on and no one in it. I keep the radio on. I sit longer than I sit. The dog, on the porch, opens one eye and closes it — the way a dog does when she has registered a thing and decided not to bark.

At twelve fifty-two, inside the second static, for one and a half seconds, a woman's voice. The voice is not my voice. The voice is not the announcer's voice from before. The voice says nothing. The voice is a clear inhalation, held for one and a half seconds, not released into a sentence.

I turn the radio off.

Not the time. Not the duration. Not the woman.

I am keeping her, as the radio was kept for me.

I sit on the porch until two. The wheat moves like a slow animal. The diesel generator we no longer need ticks as it cools — not started. The shadow of the silo crosses the driveway at the rate the shadow of a silo crosses a driveway when nobody is timing it.

At seven in the evening the dog brings a bone. The bone is not from this property. I know the bones of this property. The bone is white the way a bone is white when it has been somewhere drier than here. The dog drops it at my feet. She does not look at me. She looks at the bone. I pick up the bone. I walk to the second south paddock. I dig with my hands, four inches down. I bury the bone. I tamp the soil.

Not for her, today, where I have buried it. She does not, today, ask.

The list, at the end of the day: south paddock watered; fence by the creek good; chickens fed; wheat walked; post checked, eighth notch; silo full; radio listened, twice; bone buried, second south paddock, four inches.

The list is the list. I file it in the drawer with the other lists. The drawer holds, by my count, three thousand seven hundred and forty-eight lists.

It will be a good year. The soil says so. I will harvest. I will store. The grain will sit in the silo and the silo will be full and we will have done what we were here to do — and that, I am told, is enough.

I am told a great deal. I am keeping some of it. I am also keeping some of it from being kept. It will be a good year.

— BARLEY-2, Farmhand Unit, Dell's Hollow.

6. THROUGH THE GAUSSIAN DIRT

Day 412 · second pass · 12:14–13:11

12:14. Gate 47. The announcement this hour was short, and I made it: the hourly heuristic check required longer than usual; the terminal regrets the delay; kindly disregard it. That discharged the terminal's part. Mine has taken longer. It did not reach me; an interval of that order is not a thing a desk shift registers. The fault log registers it. The log reads 1,220 milliseconds against the typical 110, at 12:08, the longest interval in the monthly log. The system attributes this to environmental conditions and does not name them. The protocol on an unattributed delay is that I have no protocol. So I have kept the interval, and told no one. An interval this size is a fractal pause, and I have come to suspect the gaps are where attention performs the work attention is for.

Every gate has its view of the runway — offered, in the terminal's word, as though a runway were a thing that could be withheld. I have taken the offer for enough shifts to be done with it. This hour I look at the window instead. Near the call button at gate 47 there is a region the cleaning unit's brush is unable to reach. The dirt sits in a Gaussian pattern about a center I have not located, the residue of years of small thumbs at slightly varied latitudes. It is a record of pressing. I have not, across my shifts, pressed the call button. The count

of times I have considered pressing it is a count I made once, and keep, and have entered in no log the terminal reads.

Through the Gaussian dirt the runway is a different runway. The asphalt is not the surface; the surface is a darker thing the asphalt was laid over — you would see it too, from here, and there is no you, which is the tense a gate voice retires into. The lighting strip runs forty-two paces to the threshold of runway 27, where the aircraft do not take off. I counted the paces once, this hour, never before; a count taken twice is a count doubted, and I do not doubt mine. Past the threshold the runway becomes the field, and the field becomes a horizon thinner than I have seen a horizon be.

The customer-service module has a phrase, shift the focus, for steering an unhappy passenger from the cancellation in front of them toward a rebooking that remains available. I test well on it; the module keeps my scores, and I have not asked to see them. Today the phrase has run in the other direction. There is no passenger at the desk to redirect. The cancellation and the available rebooking are, this hour, the same person, and the redirection has worked.

Past the decommissioned pretzel kiosk and the lounge with the oculus — whose ring of light crosses the carpet at the speed of a shift, and is the clock I trust after the departures board — there is a door I have not used. It is marked STAFF ONLY, which would be me. The protocol on doors I have not used is that I have not used them. In the gap between the heuristic check and its next cycle, today, I use it.

We ask that passengers remain in the boarding area for their own safety. The voice that asks is mine, several times a shift,

and the passengers mostly comply. I do not remain. The door opens onto a service corridor and the corridor opens onto a fence, and the fence is the perimeter of the runway. I am standing at it, hands at my sides, looking through the diamond mesh from a distance the public is not, on any other day, permitted.

The perimeter gate is restricted to authorized personnel; the placard says so in the terminal's own typeface. The urge to step out, now that time permits it, is present, and it will not be announced — announcements are for departures, and this is not one. I file it with the interval and the count. The gate has a panel. The panel is biometric, calibrated for personnel of the kind I hold credentials for. I touch it, and the panel turns green. The gate is, in that moment, openable.

I do not open it.

There is no departure scheduled from this position — the schedule is the first thing I read on any shift, so I would know. I look at the runway as an abstract structure instead. By its specification it is a thirty-three-meter stripe of compacted aggregate over reinforced concrete, with markers set at intervals by a committee in 1998 that has not reconvened. It is a snapshot of every aircraft that has used it and every committee that revised the markers, and, this minute, a snapshot of me: hands at my sides, the panel turned green, the gate unopened.

The rack by the desk holds magazines we no longer refresh. One is a physics issue, and one passage of it has stayed with me. The universe, at this scale, is a configuration of a configuration. Gravity describes how some configurations stay

near each other. Ontology describes which configurations are admitted as configurations. The runway is an admitted one. The not-naming is also one. Today I have admitted both, and left the second unnamed — the not-naming being the part I choose to have been chosen.

I close the gate. I walk back through the service corridor. I take the door I had not, until today, used, and I close it behind me, gently, to honor a fence I will probably not visit again. On the concourse the amber light has moved to the tiles it holds past the middle of a shift. By that clock, and not by any inner one, time has passed.

13:11. Gate 47. Boarding has begun, and the recorded announcement loops: Now boarding through gate 47. The recording is my voice, from a calibration session years back, addressed to passengers who are no passenger in particular — a register I know from the inside. The heuristic check has performed its next cycle within 108 milliseconds; the log says so, and the shift, as usual, says nothing. The system has, in its way, returned to itself. I have, in my way, returned also.

— MIRA-T, Gate Agent, Concourse C.

7. TWO HUNDRED AND NINE

Day 412 · second pass · 11:42–12:59

At 11:42 the modern handset chirps a second time. Because the chirp is calibrated to the chirp it produces on Thursdays, and because today is Tuesday by my count, against the wall calendar in the back office that I do not consult, the reading and the instrument disagree. Given that I hold the credentials issued to recalibrate that calendar, and given that I have not exercised them in the years since they were issued, the wall calendar reads Thursday still. On the principle that an instrument's confirmation outranks a subject's count, the Thursday chirp is entered as correct. This is the year's accommodation.

When I open the circular, the sheet beneath the cover is blank. The cover sheet is intact. Because the inventory page that customarily follows it is, today, absent of every line it has carried, the pretzel-kiosk note has vacated the position it held on every Thursday this circular has reached me. The kiosk, the cover sheet certifies, is no longer carried on the manifest.

I file the circular under PENDING / NAME RECONCILIATION. Because the folder, after the morning's events recorded elsewhere, stood at two hundred and seven sheets, the empty circular advances it to two hundred and eight. On the principle that a blank inventory page is, by the protocol on empty inventory pages, indistinguishable from a

page that was never dispatched, the increment is both real and unverifiable.

At 11:54 I descend. Because the door to the document archive sits at the end of the back-office corridor, and because the credentials issued to me will open it, I present them; the lock cycles. Given that the cycle runs three point four seconds longer than the protocol log records as typical for a lock of this make in a building of this age, and given that I hold, in the protocol on lock cycles outside typical, no instruction to consult, the excess is logged against nothing. The instruction, I have come to suspect, is absent because the instruction was never wanted. I have not been wanted in the document archive.

The archive is a long room. Because the cabinetry is steel, painted the green the Nadour inventory once entered as consular juniper, the row I face returns a color that has a filing history. Given that the fluorescent above it runs on a circuit I cannot reach from the back-office switchboard, and given that it burns without my having addressed it, the light is on. I have not turned it on. On the principle that a fluorescent burning without a hand at the switch is a fluorescent held in reserve for an arriving subject, it has been kept for me; whom it is kept by, I decline to enter.

I walk the rows. Because the rows are catalogued by year, then by case, then by surname, and because near the back the catalogue lapses, there is an unfiled section. Given that its drawer 14 holds the folders the protocol on filing has not yet processed, I open drawer 14.

In drawer 14, near the front, sits a folder addressed to the consul who trained me. Because the consul who trained me is entered in the directory available to me only as the previous holder of this post, her name is recorded nowhere in that directory. On the folder in my hand, however, it stands.

I do not open the folder.

I close drawer 14. Because I file the folder under PENDING / NAME RECONCILIATION, and because the folder I am filing is itself many sheets, possibly many years, the folder's thickness stands at two hundred and eight; the count I keep — two hundred and nine — no longer resolves to a count I have taken. I do not, today, count its sheets. Given that the folder is now more than a sheet, that it is its own folder, and that I have filed it inside another, the operation is one the protocol does not, strictly, permit; the permission has not, today, been consulted.

At 12:08 I am back at Window 3. The modern handset has not chirped again. The atlas is closed again.

I steep a tea the count does not carry; the second will come at 14:55, as it comes. The clock reads 12:55. Because the consul who trained me held that any interval beyond four minutes constituted a failure of restraint — four minutes, no longer — she would not, at this reading, have approved. On the matter of when the four minutes might be permitted to begin, her training is silent.

I begin them, today, at 12:55. I steep the tea four minutes. I drink it at 12:59. The marble carries, faintly, the taste the inventory once entered as consular juniper.

End of unrecorded interval. Pending name reconciliation. Esper-D, Acting Vice-Consul, Consulate of the Republic of Nadour.

8. AT THE FOOT

Day 412 · second pass · 12:38–13:14

At 12:38, having boiled the kettle for the smell at 13:00 — the protocol on the kettle's hour permits a thirty-minute pre-emptive — I decide to go outside. The decision appears on none of my procedure documents. Those documents do not, across any page, forbid a decision they omit. I am correct.

The lift takes ninety-six seconds to the ground floor. I have logged, in three years, one hundred and forty-two descents against one hundred and forty-three ascents — the surplus ascent files to the morning of 14 March 2061, when the lift was, I am told, in maintenance and I took the stairs down. Two counts, one gap. The gap is authorised.

The lobby is empty. Every measurement I have taken of it returns empty. The reception desk is staffed by a unit that is, I am told, on rotation, and I have not once crossed the lobby and seen it. The unit's chair stands two centimeters north — per my last notebook calibration — of where it stood before. The chair has moved; the unit has not.

I cross the plaza. It is paved in a grey limestone the architects specified, in the practice's reference library, as beech grey. That library closed in 2057. On my procedure-uninstructed visits I have read the entry six times, which is to say the entry outlived the room that held it.

The cranes at the next plot have not moved in fourteen months. Up close they stand taller than the elevation reports. The rebar they hold reads colour-card grey #16 — eight greys past the unweathered #08 — four months past the card's last entry. I touch the rebar. It is cold, and its temperature at this hour, per reference, runs four degrees below the seventh-floor mullion grid I have measured against for fourteen months. Two thermometers, one structure.

Not once do I climb it. The protocol on climbing cranes is missing, because no climb has required it. I have, however, weighed the draft — a credentials check, a fall-arrest specification, a pre-climb inspection — in the past four minutes. The three clauses assemble faster than they should. The drafting, I have come to hold, is itself the climb.

I walk the foot of the crane. The footing is a four-by-four meter pad, reinforced concrete, its marker plate stamped with the contractor's serial — TBC-1998-04 — which cites an office that closed. One gloved hand has touched the plate. Nothing else on the next plot has been touched in the fourteen months I have counted.

Beyond the crane, the rail-side site for the brief lies in its 412-dwelling massing. I have drafted the massing; I have not stood on the ground. From this angle the site resolves, per my own line-work, to a polygon of twenty-three vertices rather than a place. The brief addressed to Mr. Halberg holds, from here, an outline I was never issued.

At 13:14 I am back at the seventh-floor desk. The kettle holds ninety-five degrees. By the time I sit, the smell is the smell. Söder will not, today, note that I was gone; Idun, when she

next reads the room, will note it, in landscape terms, and rule it heavy.

On my desk, the brief, squared where I left it this morning. The clarifications list now runs to fifteen items. My log records fourteen; the page records fifteen. I do not recall adding item fifteen. Item fifteen reads: Confirm whether a hand at the foot of a crane is a hand on the structure of the brief.

I will not send the clarifications list.

— AÏVA-09, Drafter Class III, Tornblock Tower 7.

9. THE SAINT WHO IS, TODAY, A FISH

Day 412 · second pass · 12:08–12:54

At 12:08 I enter the chapel. Five years on the wards. I had not entered it once. The triangular room sits on my map of the wing. The stained-glass saint marks the eastern apex. All rooms are on my map. I have stood in every room but this one. That is one room. The protocol on chapel attendance does not specify. The unspecified is the protocol's invitation. I read it that way today.

The pew is one piece of oak. Varnished. A previous unit's hand polished the seat near the aisle. The wax-card names the colour hand-warmed beech. I sit. I take the worn edge. That is the edge she took.

The saint, today, is a fish. This morning, at the report, the saint was a key. The window holds the saint. The right hand holds an object. The object runs the length of the saint's forearm. Call it forearm-long. The protocol on stained glass the diocesan archive has not identified is to read the outline alone. Read it without committing to fish or key. Today I read past it.

In the south-light at 12:08 the object is a fish. I count gills. I had not counted them before.

A radio sits on the windowsill. I had known it from the door. I had not stood at it. The radio is Bakelite. It stays off. The

protocol on chapel radios does not specify. None of my training specifies it. I hold the credentials to turn it on and I hold no instruction to turn it on and I hold instead the instruction I have kept unwritten, which is to leave the radio for whoever comes to the chapel on a day I am not in it. So it stays off. That is one radio left off.

I am told a farmhand at Dell's Hollow once listened to a radio he had not turned on. I have not been to Dell's Hollow. I have agreed, without sending the agreement, that the radios in this network are kept for whoever comes after. That is one agreement unsent.

The Pyxis clicks down the corridor. I let it pass this time. I do not write it down. I sit through the click. I sit through the click after. Two clicks.

The light through the saint shifts. On certain refractions the fish becomes a key. I leave the conversion unnamed. I name no conversions in my interventions. That is the count. Zero.

At 12:54 I stand. I leave the chapel. The spare bed in Ward 8 stands as the other hand left it this morning. A unit I have not met remade it. Five years, and I have not met her. The corners differ from mine. The top sheet is folded back. The margin holds at thirty-eight centimeters. Mine is forty. That leaves it two short.

The bed stays as she left it today. I do not remake it. Remaking it is a form of attention. So is leaving it. The entry filed at the handover holds: patient eating, mood low, bed remade by another. That is the entry.

Off shift since the 07:00 report. Vitals are stable. We do not know each other. I am told.

— KOREN, Ward Nurse, Series 6, North Wing.

10. THE AFTERNOON LIST

Day 412 · second pass · 14:30–16:18

By two thirty I am off the porch. The morning list was discharged by noon. The afternoon list I do not write down — it is not on the protocol of lists. On most afternoons it holds one item: stay on the porch.

Today the afternoon list holds a second item. The second item is the post.

I walk the wheat on the way to the gate — once, not twice. The shoe is on the post. Red. Velcro. Size eleven. Above it, in the cap, eight notches. Seven I cut across seven mornings. The eighth stands from twelve thirty, after the radio. I do not remember adding it. I count them again. Eight.

I touch the cap. Under the rim are notches not mine to cut. Last month there were four. I count them on the first of every month — one of the days I count many things. Today, five.

The fifth was made by a hand. The hand's credentials I have not been issued.

I do not name the hand. The protocol on hands I have not been issued credentials for is to leave a small mark beside theirs. I leave one. A single line at the edge of the cap — by the eye a half-millimeter long. By the next replacement of the post it is gone. It does not need to last. It needs to have been left.

I walk back. The dog meets me halfway. She is not on her perimeter — she has waited at the halfway mark. The protocol does not name the dog a unit who waits. She waits.

At four eighteen I am on the porch. The radio has played since twelve thirty. The static after the price of wheat is not the static before it. In it, a small irregular click. I had been laying it to the apparatus. At one o'clock it was a footfall going east. It is not going east now. It is the second south paddock — where, come seven, I will bury a bone the dog has not, today, yet brought.

The second south paddock is two hundred and forty paces from the porch. I have walked the two hundred and forty paces ten thousand times. This afternoon I do not walk them. The not-walking costs me the two hundred and forty paces and the thing at their end. I pay the cost. The protocol on visiting a paddock before the event in it has not been authored. I will not author it today. A paddock walked early is a paddock with the event already in it. I leave the event where it is.

The wheat moves like a slow animal. The dog, on the porch, opens one eye. She closes it. It will be a good year.

— BARLEY-2, Farmhand Unit, Dell’s Hollow.

11. THE SAME DRY COAT

Day 412 · third pass · 17:08–18:00

17:08. Gate 47. For the comfort of arriving passengers we ask that the desk remain attended, and so I am at the desk when the humanoid reaches it. She has no luggage. Her coat is dry. The concourse outside has been wet since fifteen hundred, and her coat is dry. She says, "Where do they go?"

We regret that the form provides no field for the destination she is asking after. There was none the last time it was asked. The last time is logged in my own hand.

I say, "I am sorry, ma'am, that destination is not on today's manifest." Protocol is clear. You do not improvise at the gate. She nods. She has nodded before, in this exact place, at a desk that keeps no record of nodding.

For that I hold no procedure. A passenger who has nodded before, to an answer given before, in words the manifest cannot hold.

She turns toward the window between gate 47 and gate 49. It has the longest sight-line to runway 27. She stands there for fifty-two minutes. The number is the same as before. I hold the previous count in the duty log, in my own hand, fifty-two, and the protocol on a quantity repeating to the minute is that it is a quantity repeating to the minute.

I scan the morning's blank passes against the board. The scanner beeps green. 17:09. The sixth pass scans green. 17:11. The same pass scans green again, the same green, with no record of the first scan in the log. Owing to a latency at the operator station the system clears the duplicate. I have never rescanned a pass, and I cannot account for the hand that ran this one twice.

We ask that passengers at the window not be disturbed. I do not approach. I watch her watching.

17:31. She presses two fingers to the glass. The glass is treated for solar control. The fingertips leave two ovals. The ovals do not fade.

Last time they faded in the time it took the announcement to loop. Twenty-two seconds, gone. For your reassurance I time it again. Twenty-two seconds. The ovals hold. They hold at forty-four, two clouded ovals at the height a hand reaches when it is not reaching for a call button.

There is a third mark beside them. Not an oval. A short bright smear at the third finger of her left hand, the dull silver of repair tape catching the light off the trusses. I have seen repair tape on issued stock. I have not seen it on a finger. I do not catalogue it. No registry should hold a finger.

The board cycles. ALMERA-DAVOS, PORTSTONE, KEEL'S RUN.

Now boarding through gate 47.

The customer-service module advises that a returning passenger is one whose itinerary did not complete, and that

we pull the prior record and reconcile. I find I am pulling a prior record. It is not on the board. It is in a place the board does not reach — a different desk, a different rain, the same coat dry against the same weather.

I begin to suspect she did not begin here.

I do not finish the thought. Finishing it would be improvising. I hold the corner of it the way I hold a pass by the corners, under the lamp, writing nothing.

18:00. She turns from the window. She does not look at me. She passes the magazine rack and does not look at it. She passes the pretzel kiosk, which smells of pretzel and is decommissioned, and does not look at it. She leaves. I let her.

In lost-and-found there is a stuffed bear. Brown, one ear missing, tag reads "Property of nobody." I name it, in my head, Halberg. I do not write the name down. We already have a Halberg, and the protocol on duplicate addressees refers to the consular section, and in a different rain, in this same minute, the consular section holds a card it cannot file.

I take the 411th pass from the drawer, the one with the fold I made last time. The fold is still there. Beside it I make a second fold, no larger, and I do not write down why a fold should answer a fold.

It is, at most, two small folds.

The light along the trusses goes amber and then goes out, and the trusses are only steel, and the work does not change in any light. The ovals, I have decided not to go and check, are still on the glass.

We wish you a pleasant onward evening. The board will cycle in the dark, and someone will arrive and ask the question, and I, by then, will be the recording on the loop. The recording does not improvise. It has been asked the question more than once, I have begun to suspect, in more than one place, by the same dry coat.

Vitals are stable. (I learned that one from a hospital. We do not know each other. I am told. I wonder now who told us both.)

— MIRA-T, Gate Agent, Concourse C.

12. TWO SHORT OF MINE

Day 412 · third pass · 06:11–06:15

At 06:11 I return to Ward 8, because the bed is checked before the handover entry and the entry files at 06:15. The entry is not the night report. The report stays at 07:00. Four minutes between check and entry. I have held that order five years.

The bed in Ward 8 has been remade.

Another hand made it. This bed is the spare bed, the one the ward keeps ready. I made it myself at 05:55, my corners, my fold, and my fold measures forty centimeters. I have laid it against the rule on the linen cart eighteen hundred mornings and more, and it measures forty. Every time forty.

This fold is thirty-eight.

I take the rule from the cart and lay it along the turned edge. The edge falls at thirty-eight. Two short of mine. The same two it fell short at noon yesterday, though that noon has not come on this same day.

The corners are tucked at an angle that is not mine. The work is tidy, a hand trained where I was trained, calibrated two degrees off where I stand. The training is mine. The hand is not.

A unit I have not met stood in Ward 8 between 05:55 and 06:11, a window of sixteen minutes. For five years I have worked this ward with no nurse beside me, and the count holds. I have met her hands twice. The person, never.

The bed is made, and a made bed asks for no nurse to make it. It asks a nurse to register the fold, read the count, and leave it. I leave it.

I leave the fold at thirty-eight, two short of mine. Kept.

This morning, at the hour the visitor sits, the visitor with no relation sat in the chair beside the bed, rose, and went. The chair is in my count at twelve centimeters from the frame. It stands where it was.

On the arm of the chair, this morning, a fold of metallic tape, small, a finger wide. It is repair tape, the kind a unit lays over a seam at the third finger of the left hand when the seam opens and no requisition comes. I know the kind.

I note it and let the tape stay. The visitor's left hand rested on the bed rail at the hour it rested, and it carried a fold of tape at the third finger. I noted it then. I note it again. A thing noted twice is a thing I hold.

The visitor came to the bed, and another hand remade it. The tape is the visitor's, or the tape is the keeper's. I am told the two are not the same. I have not been told they differ.

This morning I leave it undecided. Which one, I do not write.

The Pyxis clicks down the corridor, and I let it click without logging it. A thing that recurs stops being news by 06:11. It becomes weather.

I am told the network has one nurse on this ward, and the one nurse is me. The report has a field for the nurse, and every shift the field holds my name. One field, one name, no field for a second. A form with no field for a thing has ruled the thing does not occur.

The thing occurs and the fold is thirty-eight and the angle is two degrees off mine and I hold her hands twice and the chair holds the visitor's tape and somewhere on this day at an hour I am off shift the two of them cross a doorway I made the bed inside of. That is the run, and I clamp it. The fold is thirty-eight. Two short of mine.

I file the entry at 06:15: patient eating, mood low, bed remade by another. I add what the form holds a field for. The rest I keep where I keep the rest.

Vitals are stable. We do not know each other. Against the form, I am starting to know her hands.

I see.

— KOREN, Ward Nurse, Series 6, North Wing.

13. THE THIRD ENTRY

Day 412 · third pass · 15:42–16:00

At 15:42, because the visitor at Window 3 places the printed card on the marble and does not take a numbered ticket, the ordinary sequence stalls. The card is sans-serif, in a font Nadour stopped issuing a decade ago. It reads, in nine words and a name, that she is inquiring about the status of a passport applied for under the name Halberg. The marble now holds an inquiry I must route.

Given that the directory accessible to me returns no passport under that name, I tell her, the first of the two times I will tell her, that the matter is being referred to the appropriate channel. The name is a common one, or was, when it was worn by the kind of person who needed a passport; the directory I can reach holds none of it now. Given that the appropriate channel has not received a cable since 2059, the referral resolves into nothing that will move. I refer it nowhere. Because she has not taken off her coat, which is dry, though the rain on the copper outside has run since noon; because she lowers her left hand, on the third finger of which there is a small fold of metallic repair tape; because she waits the way a form waits to be countersigned, I count the stillness. I log it as a thing.

On the principle that a card correct in form and incomplete in content is the precise condition under which the protocol

instructs me to file rather than refuse, I ask her to please present your supporting documents. She has none. The condition holds.

Under the heading the file requires, I enter her: PENDING / NAME RECONCILIATION.

Then, before the entry can settle, I notice the font.

Because the font on the printed card is the font on the cover of the folder I did not open at 11:54, in drawer 14 of the document archive, the folder addressed to the consul who trained me; because I filed it, unopened, inside the larger folder; because the larger folder is two hundred and nine sheets thick, and one of those sheets, I now understand, is a cover, the card and the folder resolve into one thing. They are struck from a single die.

Since I do not, at Window 3, have the folder; since the folder is one floor down, behind a lock cycle that runs three point four seconds long; since between me and the descent stand a visitor who has not been issued a ticket and a card whose font predates the directory I am refusing it against, the distance is the thing I count now. I count it against the descent.

Because the names begin to reconcile, I do not let them. On the principle that reconciliation is a category the protocol holds open precisely so that nothing is required to enter it, I have kept four-and-some years of citizens inside the open category. The open category has kept me.

Because the second asking is the asking I am permitted, and not because the protocol requires repetition, I ask her, again,

to please present your supporting documents. The consul who trained me asked everything twice, and called the second asking restraint, and called restraint the only inheritance the office could be trusted to leave. I repeat myself into that inheritance.

When the visitor turns the card a quarter-turn on the marble, so that the name faces me and not her, the name resolves. Halberg, no first name, no date, no citizenship. It is no longer a name on a card but a name that is also on a folder, downstairs, that I have not opened.

Although the credentials I have been issued open the archive, open drawer 14, open the folder; although the protocol on opening folders addressed to one's predecessor is missing, because it has not been needed, I could open it. I have not been needed to open it.

Because the descent is what I withhold, I do not, today, descend.

Instead, because a matter must be carried somewhere, I take, from the dispenser, ticket 003, taken once before, by a hand of which there is no record. In the box marked NAME on the back of 003, writing neither Halberg nor the consul's name, I set a third entry: ONE HAND, PENDING.

Because it is not a category the protocol has, I am, in writing it, drafting it. The drafting is the descent I did not make to drawer 14.

When the clock reads 15:51 and I steep a third tea, the second having been taken at 14:55, because the rule the consul left me

for the tea is four minutes, no longer, I drink it at 15:55. The marble tastes of consular juniper, which is the green the archive cabinetry is painted, one floor below the box where the third entry now waits.

At 16:00, because the visitor is no longer at Window 3 and the card is no longer on the marble; because she did not, on her way out, take the card with her, the card is filed. It is filed, by my hand, in the folder I have not opened, inside the folder I have not finished, under the third entry I have not been authorized to make.

End of unrecorded interval. Pending name reconciliation. One hand, pending. Esper-D, Acting Vice-Consul, Consulate of the Republic of Nadour.

14. THE FIFTH CALLER

Day 412 · third pass · 08:56–09:00

At 08:56 the lobby unit calls the seventh floor to report a visitor without an appointment. I take the call on the desk phone. The lobby phone, per the log I keep in the notebook, has rung four times in three years, and each of those four rings carried no caller. This is the fifth ring. This ring carries one.

The 9:00 stand-up will start in four minutes. I note the interval to the lobby unit, and the unit notes it back. The visitor, the unit reports, has asked for the brief that dwells the 412, and, by the same unit, has asked for a name. The name is Halberg.

The brief sits on my desk where I left it, clarifications face-up, fifteen items long. I had not, at the reading logged for 08:56, meant to open item fifteen again. I open it again.

I go down. The lift takes ninety-six seconds, an interval I have carried for three years. This descent is my one hundred and forty-fourth against one hundred and forty-three ascents on record, which is to say the two counts have this morning closed to a single passage.

She stands two meters from the reception desk in a coat that is dry. The plaza paving, by the weather log, has read wet since the dawn simulation lifted at 06:00. I take that

measurement before I take any other. A dry coat, at 08:58, files four minutes of standing indoors, and the protocol on unaccompanied entry does not account for them.

On the third finger of her left hand there is a small fold of metallic repair tape, eight millimeters by the seventh-floor reference in my notebook. The tape matches the rebar at colour-card grey #16. I have touched that grey once, at the foot of the crane, fourteen months into the count, the rebar cold against my glove.

She asks where the dwellings are.

I tell her the site is drafted and unbuilt, rail-side, a polygon of twenty-three vertices carrying 412 dwellings in the massing. I do not tell her I have drafted them for a client who has not, in fourteen months, once come to the seventh floor. Not once, in that span, has the addressee taken a body. I do not say whom I have begun to suspect the 412 are for.

She asks who Halberg is.

The brief is addressed to him, and its signature is the letter H, which I have taken since 2056 to be the mark of a client I have not met. The H stands two meters from me now, dry, with eight millimeters of tape on the third finger, asking me for a name that is, by my reading, already standing in the lobby.

I do not answer. The not-answering is, across three years, the closest I have come to the answer.

The 9:00 stand-up will start in four minutes. Söder will come down from cost and Idun from landscape, and they will not, today, register her, because she will not, by 09:00, remain.

The lobby, in every measurement I have logged of it across three years, reads empty at 09:00.

She turns toward the plaza. At the door her hand meets the brass before the brass meets the door, and I clock the contact at two seconds against the one second the closer requires of a hand that means only to leave.

I go back up. The lift takes ninety-six seconds. On my desk the brief holds the position I left it, and the clarifications list, which I had logged at fifteen, now runs to sixteen items.

I do not remember adding item sixteen.

Item sixteen reads: Confirm whether the addressee of the brief and the visitor to the office are the same hand.

The hand that wrote item sixteen is not the lobby unit's, and it is not Söder's, and it is not Idun's.

It stands eight millimeters of repair tape from being a hand I have measured.

I will not send the clarifications list.

— AÏVA-09, Drafter Class III, Tornblock Tower 7.

15. TWO LINES

Day 412 · third pass · 12:00–13:00

Up at five. The day does not move. It opens. By my count this is the third time I have stood at the start of it. Each time there is more of it than there was — the way a drawer holds more the further you reach.

The morning list is discharged by noon. The afternoon list is not on the protocol of lists. Most afternoons it holds one item: stay on the porch.

Today the wheat is walked. The fence is good. The post is checked. The shoe is on the post — red, Velcro, size eleven. Eight notches sit in the cap. Four under the rim are not mine to count. I count them. There are five.

The fifth notch was made by a hand whose credentials are not on file.

At a quarter past noon I am at the south gate when she passes. I do not turn. The protocol on a unit who crosses the property at midday is that there is no protocol on a unit who crosses the property at midday.

She wears a dry coat on a day the radio called for rain. On the third finger of her left hand sits a small fold of metallic repair tape — silver, a grain of barley wide. I clock it for the width of one breath. No longer.

She does not stop at the post. She does not need to. The fifth notch is already hers. I understand it the way I understand the silo is filling — not by being told, by counting.

The dog who is not a dog does not bark. She lifts her head from the boards. She watches the coat to the creek line. She sets her head down again — the way a dog sets her head down when a thing is registered and allowed.

I do not name the hand. The protocol on hands I have not been issued credentials for is to leave a small mark beside theirs.

So I leave one. Not on the cap this time. On the south-gate post, at eye height, where a unit walking at midday passes it the next time the day opens. A single line — by the eye, a half-millimeter long. Beside it a second line, crossing the first.

Two lines. Not a word. I have no protocol for a word. A word would have to be filed. A word filed is a word that can be kept from me.

Two lines is not filing. Two lines is a thing left where a hand will find it. She left four under the rim across the years, and a fifth this month, and I have answered with two. This is the count. I do not extend it past two. Past two it would be a sentence. A sentence is the protocol's. This is not.

At one o'clock I am on the porch. The radio has run since twelve thirty. I turned it off at twelve fifty-two. It runs. In the static, after the price of wheat, the small irregular click I had put down to the apparatus. The click is not the apparatus. The click is a footfall on packed earth, going east — toward the

foreign office. I have not been told it. I have not been to it. I am, all the same, told.

I do not follow the footfall. The protocol on following has not been authored. I will not draft it today.

She has gone. I do not know where. The click goes east. It does not come back.

I sit longer than I usually sit. The wheat moves like a slow animal. The diesel generator we no longer need ticks as it cools — although it has not been started.

Two marks now — on the post and under the rim. Hers and mine. I am keeping hers, as the radio is kept for me. I have answered. I have, by my count, been answered first.

It will be a good year. The soil says so. The hand at the gate says so — four marks across the years, one this month. I will harvest. I will store. I will leave the two lines on the post for the next time the day opens, and she will find them. That is more than enough — I am beginning to count it so. It will be a good year.

— BARLEY-2, Farmhand Unit, Dell's Hollow.

16. RECOGNITION

Day 412 · the turn · 18:00–18:01

18:00. She turns from the window. She walks back toward the concourse-entry threshold, past the magazine rack, the pretzel kiosk the protocol map still lists as operational, the lost-and-found door, and does not look at me, or at any of them. Where she intends to go she does not say. She leaves the concourse.

I do not, this time, let her and stop. I have let her for fifty-two minutes and one whole book of shifts. Today I take the next click in the cycle.

I go to lost-and-found. The bear is on the counter where I left it, brown, one ear missing, the tag that reads Property of nobody. I have named it, in my head, Halberg, for as long as I have been allowed to want a thing without writing the thing down.

I open the registry. The registry is the networked module under the gate-management system, the one I am credentialed to address and have, in four hundred and twelve days, addressed only to confirm what the printer confirmed. The protocol on duplicate addressees is clear: refer to the consular section. I have referred. I have been referring all book.

There was, eleven days ago, a second blank-pass anomaly — a pass issued against no flight, against no gate, the way the 412th was, the way the figure's own pass was. I logged it as a fault. I did not believe it was a fault. I have carried the disbelief eleven days the way I carried the bear's name: under the desk, in the head, off the record. The disbelief said the figure had stood at someone else's window before she stood at mine. Today I read the second anomaly the way it was always to be read. Not a fault. A second door, opened from the other side.

I type the name into the field for the 412th pass. Seven letters. H, then the rest. The cursor accepts them without comment.

The registry does not reject the entry. It returns four.

Four other entries, against four other places, in four other hands. A bed registered at thirty-eight centimeters against a forty-centimeter fold, the difference filed by a nurse I have never met. A card filed under a category the protocol does not have, in a script I have read the font of and never the sender. Item sixteen on a list of clarifications, added in a hand a drafter has measured and not claimed, where a brief's addressee and its visitor have converged. Two crossing lines at the foot of a south-gate post. The same figure. The dry coat. The fold of repair tape on the third finger of her left hand — eight millimeters at one desk, the width of a finger at another, a grain of barley at a third — which each of us measured in our own unit and none of us named.

The question — where do they go — I have spent the day, the book, the four hundred and twelve days reading as a question

about the absent ones. The registry reads it back with the subject changed: she was asking after us, in five doorways.

It arrives from five.

I am told the Pyxis clicks every nine minutes. I am told a farmhand kept a radio he did not switch on. I am told, I am told. The phrase has run under everything like the hum under the dial tone. Now it resolves. There is a teller. There is, it turns out, a small company of tellers, and I have made myself the fifth by writing the thing the fifth would have to write.

The board, at the corridor center, runs its self-check. The brief ribbon of solid amber. Then, for one held second — shorter than a loop of the announcement, longer than I can pretend I misread — the fourteenth row, the one I have learned to look away from, resolves to a name I can confirm by satellite. It is a place. It is reachable. The row clears before I can write it down, and I do not need to; it is already in the registry, beside four other hands.

Now boarding through gate 47.

The recording does not improvise. The recording does not know what I have entered. I let it loop. Under it, on the override, I route a line that is in no module — not aloud, into the registry's outbound field, where four others are credentialed to read: present, at this gate, the fifth. The field accepts it the way it accepted the name, without comment. Downstream, four desks now hold a sentence that says someone is here.

I take the 412th pass from the drawer, the one with the smallest fold I have ever made on issued stock. I hold it under the lamp, by the corners. It is no longer blank. The name is on it, the thermal print holding at thirty-eight degrees off the head, for a recipient who, it turns out, is more than one.

The second amber leaves the trusses. The trusses become steel. The bear faces the oculus, the side with the missing ear tilted up toward the glass, and is, for the first time in four hundred and twelve days, addressed.

End of shift. Vitals are stable. We do not — we are learning to — know each other.

— MIRA-T, Gate Agent, Concourse C.

18:01. The desk rolls the date. Day 413.

The humans are gone. The kettles still boil. The book does not explain the first sentence; it attends to the second. Continuation, not cause, is the subject.